

Next a coat of coarser texture
 Did she four times wrap around him,
 O'er that garment, blue in colour,
 Which was newest of the newest,
 Next she cast a fur, with buttons,
 With an hundred gay adornments,
 O'er the coat of coarser texture,
 Which a finer cloth encircled.
 Then about his hips his girdle
 Did she bind, with gold embroidered,
 Which her mother's needle work'd once,
 While she helped her in the labour.
 Then the gloves of wondrous pattern,
 Gloves with fingers and gold edges,
 Which the Laplander had fashioned,
 On his well-shaped hands she fitted.
 Then the cap she brought, which trembled
 As it pressed his golden tresses;
 'Twas the cap his father purchased
 When in youth he went a-wooing."

The reader will have no difficulty in understanding how a poem written on this principle can be spun out to any given number of lines. However, it is to this prolixity of description that the Kalewala owes much of its value as a record of the details of Finnish life.

To attempt any conjecture as to the veritable import of the Kalewala,—as to the nucleus of truth, moral, historical, or theological, that would remain if it were stripped of its wild fancies,—would be an act of ridiculous presumption, as the profoundest investigators of the subject are still in the profoundest darkness. There are certain features, however, which may be pointed out, and which may lead the reader to make reflections for his own benefit.

Throughout the whole poem a contest is carried on between the races of Kalewala and Pohjola; the former represented by the three heroes, Wiinämöinen, Ilmarinen, and Ahti, the latter by the witch Louhi. Some interpreters would find in this contest a mythical indication of the antagonism between good and evil. To this ethical solution of the fable Alexander Castrén shrewdly objects, that neither of the contending parties is sufficiently pure in intent or action to stand as the representative of perfect good. He would rather give an historical than a mythical interpretation to the long tale of the wooing of Louhi's daughter. Among the nations to which the story refers, it seems to have been an imperative law that a man could not marry a woman of his own family or clan. He must seek a wife beyond the wide precincts of his kinsfolk; and thus, as nearly all the clans were in a state of hostility, courtship was a matter of no small difficulty, while forcible abduction was in the natural order of things. The constant appearance of the heroes of Kalewala as suitors to the maidens of Pohjola, notwithstanding their detestation of the hostess, is therefore quite consistent with the manners of the people. Castrén is also of opinion that the opposition between Kalewala and Pohjola was sung when the Finns had not yet quitted their Asiatic birth-place. However,